

NICK RIOS

PRINCIPAL ENGINEER

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Principal engineer with 20 years building enterprise-scale platforms. Hands-on: designs and ships production systems, leads local and offshore teams, and drives projects into reality. Based in Austin, TX.

EXPERIENCE

Digital Harbor — Team Lead & AI Architect

Sep 2020 – Mar 2025

Earned team lead over three initiatives through delivery. A relentless idea promoter in a company that ran on brainstorming; led an innovation track. Selected for company-wide leadership retreat.

- Made core contributions to Set-Forms across the builder and server layers
- Delivered templating, theming, chat, and next-gen forms — before the AI era began
- Championed the ui-style-library that unified multiple Angular teams, cutting time-to-production 80%
- Once AI landed, pivoted to HTML generation and AI-powered WYSIWYG — live UI from LLM command schemas
- AI agent management and rapid API deployment platform that became the backbone of 100+ services
- Built the image API adopted company-wide, integrating media providers for simple consumption
- Designed RAG pipelines for structured and unstructured data, with and without LangChain
- Put an AI code reviewer on every GitLab check-in, pushing diff-based reviews to Teams
- Stabilized failing products through simplification and refactoring
- Ran weekly AI innovation calls; led demos and cross-team sessions; onboarded new hires

Cisco Systems — Senior Engineer

Dec 2012 – Mar 2020

Took an enterprise alerting and ticketing platform from internal launch to public release — earning multiple team leadership positions along the way. A data-science and performance shop at heart: UI patterns so optimized the team spent its time on data transformations, not pixels.

- Solved multi-source data ingestion into a single Elasticsearch source of truth
- Launched Neo4j at enterprise scale; its founders flew to Austin to meet the team after signup
- Key part of the Splunk rollout — my team owned the top-level single pane of glass
- Won a global innovation award at all-hands; demoed the product live to 4,000+ viewers including SVPs
- Primary interface between engineering, product, design, and stakeholders; influenced roadmap
- Led local and offshore teams; scaled high-volume event ingestion and search
- Shipped Angular components and API specifications adopted company-wide
- Designed the hiring screen, conducted interviews, and ran the team's scrum
- Built lasting cross-org relationships across engineering, product, and design

EARLIER ROLES

Impremedia	Consolidated major newspaper publishers into a single digital CMS	2009 – 2012
Nexstar Broadcasting	Migrated 60+ TV stations to a multi-tenant CMS serving 1M+ daily	2005 – 2009
AT&T & Sprint	Telecom operations roles prior to moving into software engineering	2001 – 2005

CAREER TIMELINE

2001–2005 · Telecom → Systems — Started in telecom operations at AT&T and Sprint, CNA, Network+, hands-on

2005–2012 · Media & Web Platforms — Consolidated DAM platforms for national content publishers

2012–2020 · Enterprise Infrastructure — Scaled enterprise data, and grew from engineer into trusted team leadership

2020–2025 · AI Platforms & Leadership — Led teams through a company's AI adoption, building innovative products

LEADERSHIP & PRACTICES

- Lead by example, taking on the most complex or cross-cutting work
- Create open environments where blockers become shared responsibility
- Build consistent, narrow processes from design to deployment
- Launch rapid proofs of concept; build long runways for complex challenges
- Schema-backed system design: declare the model once, eliminate boilerplate, and accelerate development

CORE SKILLS

AI & LLM Systems	AI agent platform and LLM automations, RAG pipelines and automated code review
Full-Stack Delivery	Ships web products end to end, from architecture to deployment, that scale rapidly
Systems & Architecture	Designs multi-tenant, high-volume platforms built to last for years, not sprints
Front-end Engineering	20 years shipping fast, accessible interfaces across major front-end framework
Team Leadership	Leads engineering teams through hiring, mentorship, and stakeholder alignment

INDEPENDENT & SIDE WORK

Storyboarder	Script-to-storyboard AI pipeline using OpenAI, Veo, LTX-Video, Spark-TTS, Modal, Railway
Claude Skill	Authored a published Claude skill for consistent, high-quality system design
AI Experiments	AI-powered blogs and chat-bots; search with Pinecone and LangChain; n8n automation
E-commerce	Built and launched drakomotors.com and hatsyshirtsy.com storefronts
Poker Platform	Real-time multiplayer poker site built with React Native and WebSockets
Client Work	Engagements with Armory Agency and Lifeblue Studios

INTERESTS

Outside of work, Nick is a hobbyist filmmaker and video editor, writes for YouTube, and enjoys a good game of poker. Most of all, he values time with family, especially their trips to the mountains. Repeat SXSW volunteer and tapped into the Austin music, comedy and technology scene.